

Chicago Tribune



\$4.00 | MONDAY, MARCH 30, 2026 | CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Study: Property taxes double rate of inflation

Report by Cook treasurer’s office examines rates in county over past 30 years, urges state reforms

By Rick Pearson
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Property taxes imposed by government bodies within Cook County’s borders have grown at twice the rate of inflation over the past three decades, outpacing wage growth and driving an affordability crisis, a study by Cook County

Treasurer Maria Pappas’ office has found.

Pappas’ report, released Monday morning, condemns political leaders — many of them Democrats like herself — for exploiting loopholes in a state law designed to limit real estate tax increases. It calls on Democratic Gov. JB Pritzker and the Democratic-led General Assem-

bly to enact significant reforms and find ways for local taxing agencies to cut spending.

“Illinois in 2025 had the dubious distinction of having the highest residential property tax rate in the nation. Chicago has the highest commercial rate in the U.S.,” Pappas said in a statement accompanying the study. “It’s time for the governor, state lawmakers and local government leaders to come up with a reform plan that works for taxpayers.”

Pappas’ report, titled “How State Laws Failed to Stop Decades of Skyrocketing Property Taxes: A Case for Reform,” arrives as the Illinois Department of Revenue is completing its own study of the state’s property tax system, due at the end of July. But Pappas said in her report that it was time for politicians to act “rather than produce another report that gets put on a shelf to gather cobwebs.”

Her study also comes in an election year when high property taxes

are sure to be a major campaign issue in Pritzker’s race for a third term versus Republican Darren Bailey, as well as other statewide and scores of state legislative races. But large-scale remedies, such as finding alternative sources of revenue like a general tax increase to offset property tax cuts, are less likely when lawmakers and Pritzker are seeking reelection — though political pressures are lessened after

See **TAXES** on Page A2



Kevin McVey stands outside the building at 55 E. Monroe St. in Chicago where immigration court is held after observing morning proceedings on March 23. “It’s a very emotional experience to go in person,” McVey says. **BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Access denied

Immigration court observers — and their oversight — are routinely locked out of the process as judges move the hearings online

By Caroline Kubzansky
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Ruth Abramson sees her volunteer work observing Chicago’s immigration court as a way to practice tikkun olam — the Hebrew phrase for repairing the world.

On a recent March morning, Abramson was trying to access a web link to a master calendar hearing taking place at Chicago immigration court — a sort of judicial cattle call where judges check in on a litany of different cases. But 9 a.m. came and went and she was still in the digital waiting room.

As she listens remotely to court appearances for parades of immigrants and

their attorneys for a morning each week, Abramson, 66, hears echoes of her own family’s story. They were Eastern European Jews who escaped antisemitic pogroms and arrived in the U.S. with nothing.

“There but for the grace of God go I,” she said. Her voice caught. She was waiting at her desk for proceedings to begin. She straightened up and continued: “Anyway, we should try to get on and see what the situation is.”

Post-pandemic, the number of immigration court hearings conducted on a virtual platform called Webex has skyrocketed. But over the last few months, court watchers trying to observe on that platform increasingly have found them-

selves shut out of those hearings.

Of the 17 permanent and temporary judges staffing the city’s immigration court, observers from Abramson’s group have not been able to access virtual proceedings run by four judges since January. Another two appeared to stop allowing virtual access in February.

The observers are facing the shutouts at a moment of uncertainty for immigrants who are seeking to obtain legal status around the country against a tide of new policies from the Trump administration, along with an exodus of judges and a sprawling legal fight over basic tenets of the court process.

See **OBSERVERS** on Page A6

Pakistan to host US-Iran talks

Iranian forces await American troops as Israel eyes Lebanon

By Munir Ahmed,
Sam Metz
and Samy Magdy
ASSOCIATED PRESS

ISLAMABAD — Pakistan announced Sunday that it will soon host talks between the U.S. and Iran, though there was no immediate word from Washington or Tehran, and it was unclear whether the talks on the month-long war would be direct or indirect.

“Pakistan is very happy that both Iran and the U.S. have expressed their confidence in Pakistan to facilitate the talks. Pakistan will be honored to host and facilitate meaningful talks between the two sides in the coming days,” Foreign Minister Ishaq Dar said in a speech after top diplomats from Turkey, Egypt and Saudi Arabia met in Islamabad.

Pakistan later said the diplomats had departed for their home countries. The talks were originally scheduled to continue Monday.

Pakistan’s foreign ministry did not answer questions. Islamabad has emerged as a mediator, having relatively good ties with Washington and Tehran. Pakistani officials have said their public effort follows weeks of quiet diplomacy.

Earlier, Iran’s parliament speaker, Mohammad Bagher Qalibaf, dismissed the talks in Pakistan as a cover after some 2,500 U.S. Marines trained in amphibious landings arrived in the Middle East. He said Iranian forces were “waiting for the arrival of American troops on the ground to set them on fire and punish their regional partners forever,” according to state media.

See **OBSERVERS** on Page A10

INSIDE

Fired up for the Four

The University of Illinois campus at Urbana-Champaign burst into celebration after the men’s basketball team became the school’s first in more than 20 years to win a spot in the Final Four of the NCAA Tournament. The Fighting Illini defeated Iowa in the Elite Eight game on Saturday, sending hordes of students to the Alma Mater statue on campus. **Chicagoland, Page A3**

Student fans pose for pictures with police officers on campus after Illinois’ win on Saturday. **JOHN J. KIM/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**



Deaths in ICE custody grow

Thirteen people have died in federal immigration custody in the first three months of this year, and 46 have died since President Donald Trump took office last year. **Nation & World, Page B1**

Tech firms devour energy

The race to deploy artificial intelligence is complicating their commitments to reduce greenhouse gas emissions, most of which come from the burning of gas, oil and coal. **Nation & World, Page B4**

SUBSCRIPTION

Visit myaccount.chicagotribune.com or call 312-546-7900 to sign up for a subscription. To place an ad, visit placeanad.chicagotribune.com.

WEATHER FORECAST

TODAY H: 76 L: 64
TUE. H: 76 L: 37
WED. H: 41 L: 37
Complete details on Page A12

INDEX

Almanac A10
Arts & Living B5
Comics B8-9
Crossword B9
Editorials A7
Horoscope B8
Nation & World B1
Obituaries A10
Television B7

178th year No. 89
© Chicago Tribune

